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# A VRy tough decision

With all the big VR devices nearing launch day, which one would you buy?

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At first, 2014 was purported to be “The year of the VR” and then 2015 has been called the same. Given all the release news around this new segment, I now feel that I too must add my voice to the chorus except for one minor difference. The year will be 2016. And this isn't a prophetic declaration, we know that all consumer VR units will finally be available in the coming year. Valve and HTC's VIVE is slated for a November 2015 launch which we Indians might not be able to get our hands on for quite some time. Sony's Morpheus will hit the shelves sometime in the first half of 2016, and if Sony's PS4 launch in India is anything to go by then we might end up seeing the device a few months after the international launch with a hefty price tag thanks to the “current Indian tax structure.” And lastly, we have the Oculus Rift which finally has a release date in the first quarter of the coming year. You can see where I'm going with this.

Technology wise the three giants will try to match each other. Oculus' consumer version is expected to come out with a 2160x1200 display running at 90Hz. On the other hand HTC's Vive will have 1200x1080 panels for each eye and they're both running at 90Hz. Lastly, Sony's Morpheus will have 960x1080 panels for each eye. While the Vive seems



HTC VIVE a.k.a. SteamVR

to have the lead here, there's the fact that the hardware that has to drive these devices will require quite the horsepower. Moreover, since Morpheus is restricted to the PS4, something that Sony rules over with an iron fist, you can rest assured that your experience will be uniform across all titles that support VR on Sony's console. The Vive and Oculus don't have it easy, not only is the hardware requirement for either unit astronomical, the two ecosystems aren't as controlled as Sony's. Valve might take a few steps to ensure a good experience for the games released on the Vive but Oculus is playing on a completely open playing field. On a recent blog post they'd outlined the recommended specifications for the consumer version of the Rift. An Intel i5-4590, NVIDIA GTX 970 or AMD R9 290 and 8 GB of RAM will cost you about ₹40K and the remaining components should jack the price up by about ₹20-30K. All things

considered, a Rift capable system coupled with the Oculus Rift itself should set you back by about \$1,500 (or ₹95,000). That price is a bit steep indeed.

For years upon years, I've been classified as an early adopter but this is one thing that seems way too much for the money. I have the GTX 970, 16 GB of RAM and an i7-3770K, so hardware isn't a concern for me, but it is a concern for most gamers. Few gamers have access to anything more than integrated graphics and if the Rift was niche before, the requirement of a 970 (OK, it's only the “recommended” hardware, but still...) makes it even more niche. I'm almost tempted to get the DK2 and would have gotten one already if it weren't for the glaringly painful drawbacks. It's quite heavy, has latency issues and a noticeable screen-door effect owing to the lower resolution.

There are cheaper VR devices, but most of them have partnered with some